

► JAYDEEP SARKAR, 28 SHAURYA

"Production houses are now developing scripts because not every film can have Akshay Kumar."



bestsellers and working in Singapore and Hong Kong, the 33-year-old moved to Mumbai earlier this year, following his wife, who is COO of UBS. He hasn't quit his comfortable job as director, distressed projects group, at Deutsche Bank, but he's knee-deep in Bollywood now, having adapted the screenplay of *Hello*, a forthcoming film based on his last book, *One Night @ the Call Centre*. His first book, *Five Point Someone*, forms the core of Raju Hirani's next film, *Idiots*. His new book, *The Three Mistakes of My Life*, has evinced a lot of interest among producers—not surprisingly, because it tells the story of three young men against the backdrop of the Gujarat riots.

It's a frenzy of acquisition out there, especially if quality is backed with success. As Acharya says, "Doors open much faster even though some of the doormen (read old school producers) haven't seen *Loins*. The box office performance alone is enough for them to say, 'You are the future'." It's a future Dutt Guptan wanted ever since she saw *Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge* as a 24-year-old with her boss at that time, Rekha Nigam (who quit her job to move to scriptwriting four years ago). Little did she know that she would soon attract the attention of the director of that film, Aditya Chopra. She has not only written the dialogues and songs for the forthcoming Yash Raj

Films' *Bachna Ae Haseeno* and Dharma Productions' *Dostana*, but also penned *Kambakht Ishq*, a film based in Los Angeles, about a hands-and-feet model and a Hollywood stuntman, for Sajid Nadiadwala.

If the 36-year-old has acquired quite a reputation for hip, urbane characters, Faisal has acquired one for non-cliche dialogues. In this new world, light years away from Dutt Guptan's ads set in Meerut rooftops and Delhi's bylanes or Faisal's militancy-torn haunt, Kashmir, the writers are learning to adapt. It's not just a simple must-do like addressing everyone with the suffix *ji*, regardless of their age. Or of learning to live with compromises such as having to insert an item song at the beginning of a film dealing with communalism. It's also about getting used to another idiom. For some it comes naturally. Dutt Guptan says she has no desire to write only for "myself, three critics and 17 English-speaking viewers". For others, it's about creating another country, big enough to appreciate their slightly off-centre humour—*The President is Coming* is about six Indians who compete with one another to shake hands with George Bush when he visits India, a riff on both America and India's obsession with it.

Most major production houses are

now willing to invest in good scripts. It could be Ritesh Sidhwani who thought nothing of offering a film to 36-year-old former Jet Airways flight attendant Althea Delmas-Kaushal after she read out 65 pages of a story to him, Farhan and Zoya Akhtar at breakneck speed—the film is now going to be directed by ad filmmaker Abhinay Deo. It could also be someone like Pooja Shetty, who has Ankur Tewari (who co-directed a Hindi-English satire, *Let's Enjoy*) as a script doctor for two films she is developing for her new company. "Bollywood has a reputation for not paying writers. Plus, no one wants to risk working with a totally new person," says Shetty.

When are we going to see out Diablo Cody—the stripper-turned-writer of the inventive indie hit *Juno*—she asks. The success of Jaideep Sahni, who wrote *Bunty Aur Babli* and *Chak De! India*, and Rensil D'Silva, who co-wrote *Rang De Basanti*, has much to do with the new crop. If Sahni can get away with subversion (from taking on Mayawati to twitting the hockey establishment), it paves the way for others who want to knock down a few notions. Says former journalist Samar Khan, 36, who directed *Shaurya*, "Every film has to have a point of view. It should be able to say something." If a writer's experience stretches beyond Hill Road in Bandra, an opinion is easier to acquire—as is the craft to back it. ■